

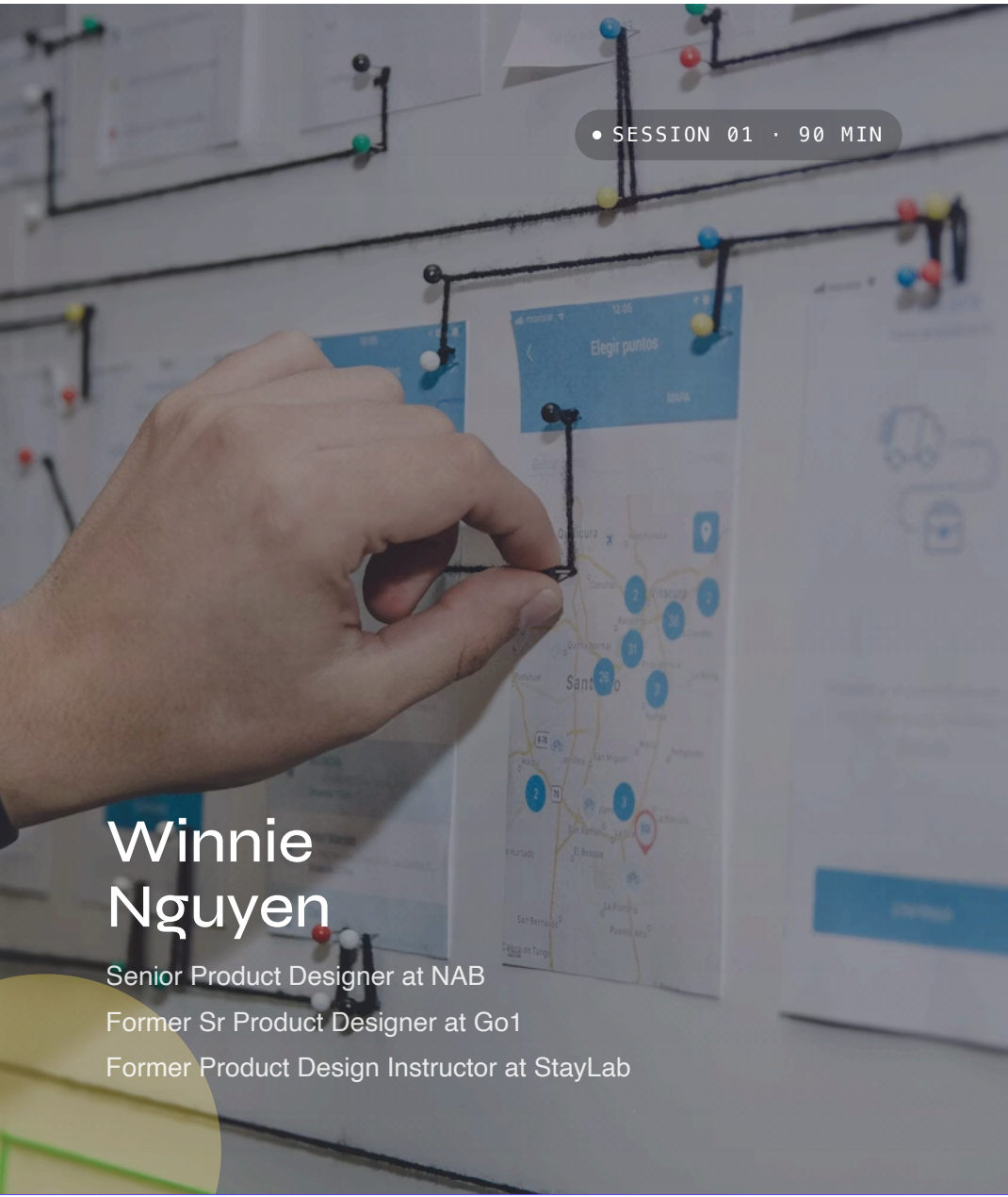
2026 · Winnie Nguyen

SESSION 01

Design Thinking for UX

From solving requirements to solving real problems.

• SESSION 01 • 90 MIN

A hand is pointing at a map on a wall. The wall is covered with various pins, sticky notes, and a map. The map shows a route with numbered points. The hand is pointing at one of the points on the map.

Winnie
Nguyen

Senior Product Designer at NAB

Former Sr Product Designer at Go1

Former Product Design Instructor at StayLab

LET'S START HERE

10 minutes to reflect

What's one moment you struggled when starting a new initiative? Take two minutes to think of a real example — then we'll share.

— SOUND FAMILIAR?

We're designing for requirements, not for people

- 01** Designing from the brief
Treating requirements as truth — without questioning whether they solve a real problem.
- 02** Jumping to hi-fidelity
Opening the design tool the moment a brief arrives, before understanding anyone.
- 03** Working in isolation
Cut off from real users and other teams — so assumptions go unchallenged.

"But does it really make the people happy?"

THE REAL GAP

The problem isn't a lack of design skill. It's a lack of **design thinking.**

Between knowing nothing and a confident solution sits a messy middle — understanding people, framing the real problem, exploring options. That middle is where design thinking lives.

THEORY

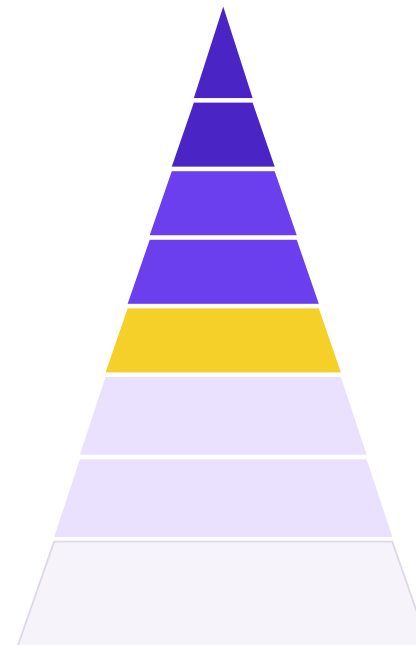
Design Thinking is a human-centered problem-solving method — to understand needs, challenge assumptions, and create solutions.

— WHERE PROCESS FITS

Most talk lives at the bottom. **Growth lives at the top.**

Tools and visual craft dominate hiring conversations. The layers that drive senior impact — process, communication, ownership, strategy — get far less attention.

"90% OF DISCUSSION" → THE BASE · AFTER @ARTIOM DASHINSKY



LEADERSHIP

- Advocacy
- Mentorship
- Strategy
- Ownership
- Design Process — where Design Thinking lives

FOUNDATIONS

- Communication
- Collaboration
- UX & Visual Design
- Tools

Process is what makes decisions defensible

WITHOUT PROCESS

Solutions decided before the problem is understood.

- The brief is treated as truth.
- Assumptions stay invisible until it's too late.
- Late pivots are expensive and demoralising.

WITH PROCESS

Decisions grounded in user evidence.

- Assumptions are surfaced early.
- Research actually changes what gets built.
- Fewer surprises at launch.

— THE FRAMEWORK

The 5-stage cycle

01

Empathise

What is actually going on with users — not what we assume?

02

Define

What is the real problem worth solving?

03

Ideate

What are all the possible ways to solve it?

04

Prototype

What is the fastest way to make this testable?

05

Test

Were we right? What do we need to change?

Non-linear — move freely between stages as insights emerge.

— THE REALITY

Most teams skip stages 1 and 2

01

Empathise

What is actually going on with users?

02

Define

What is the real problem worth solving?

03

Ideate

What are all the possible ways to solve it?

← TEAMS START HERE

04

Prototype

What is the fastest way to make this testable?

05

Test

Were we right? What needs to change?

*A brief is **not** a problem definition.*

Five stages, **five outputs**

- 01** Understand users first
Research brief, interviews, assumption map.
- 02** Frame the real problem
Insight statements, problem statement, jobs-to-be-done.
- 03** Organise for users
Evidence-based sitemap and task flows.
- 04** Build to answer questions
Wireframes, prototype, decision log.
- 05** Find out if you were right
Test synthesis and an iterated prototype.

01 STAGE ONE

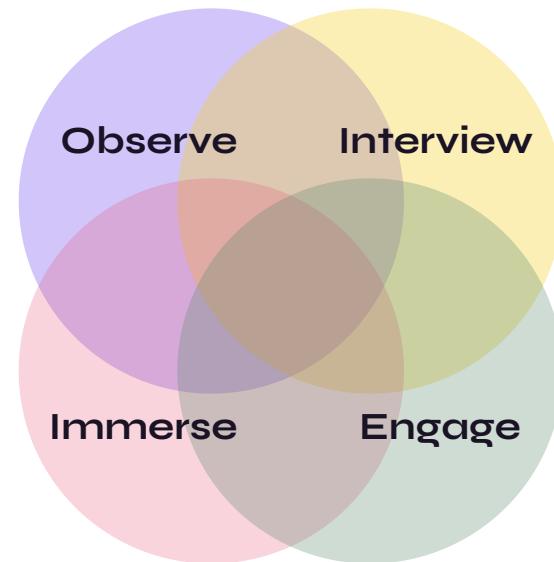
Empathise

What is actually going on with users — not what we assume?

— BEFORE ANY SOLUTION THINKING

Understand people — not just their actions

Four modes of empathic research work together as overlapping ways of seeing the same person.



— STAGE 1 · DISCOVERY

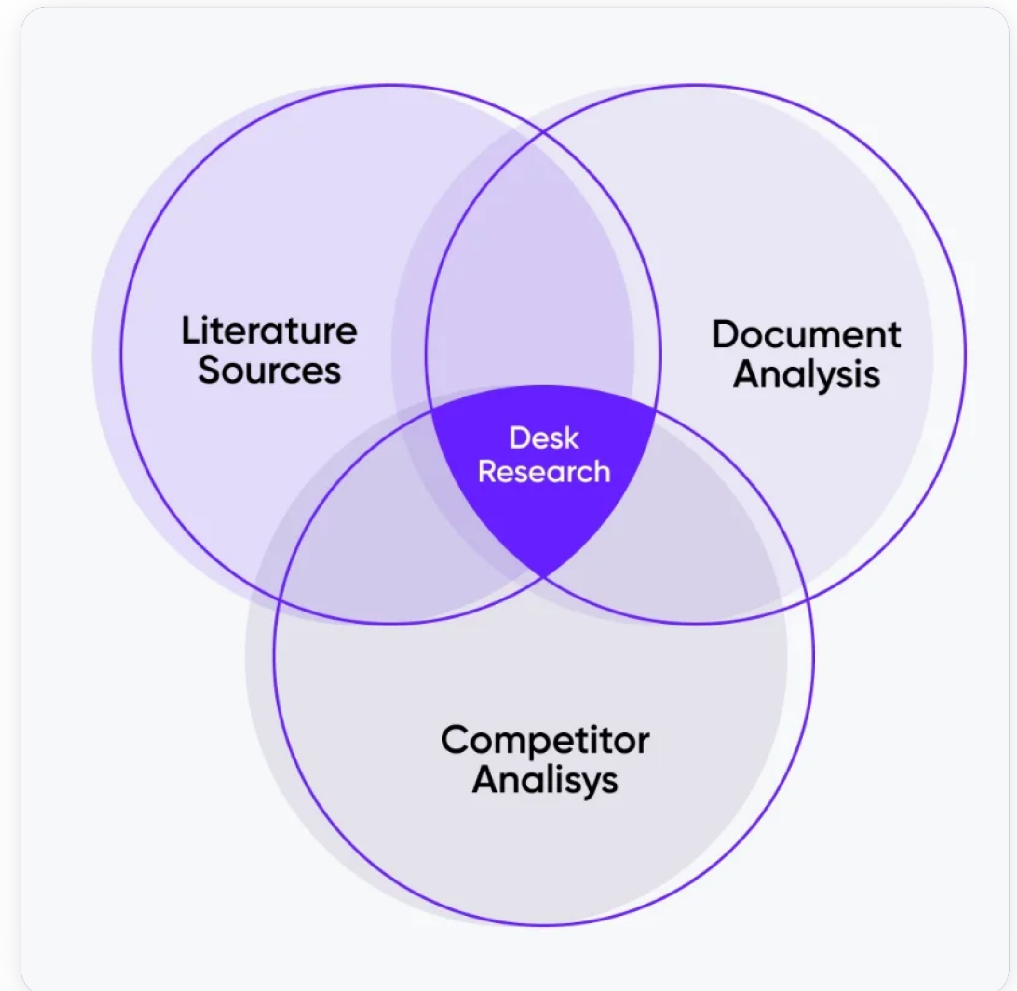
Desk research

Competitor review, market reports, and analytics — done before primary research to ground your starting assumptions.

DISCOVERY

SECONDARY RESEARCH

½ DAY



— SOURCE [CIEDEN.COM](https://cieden.com)

— STAGE 1 • DISCOVERY

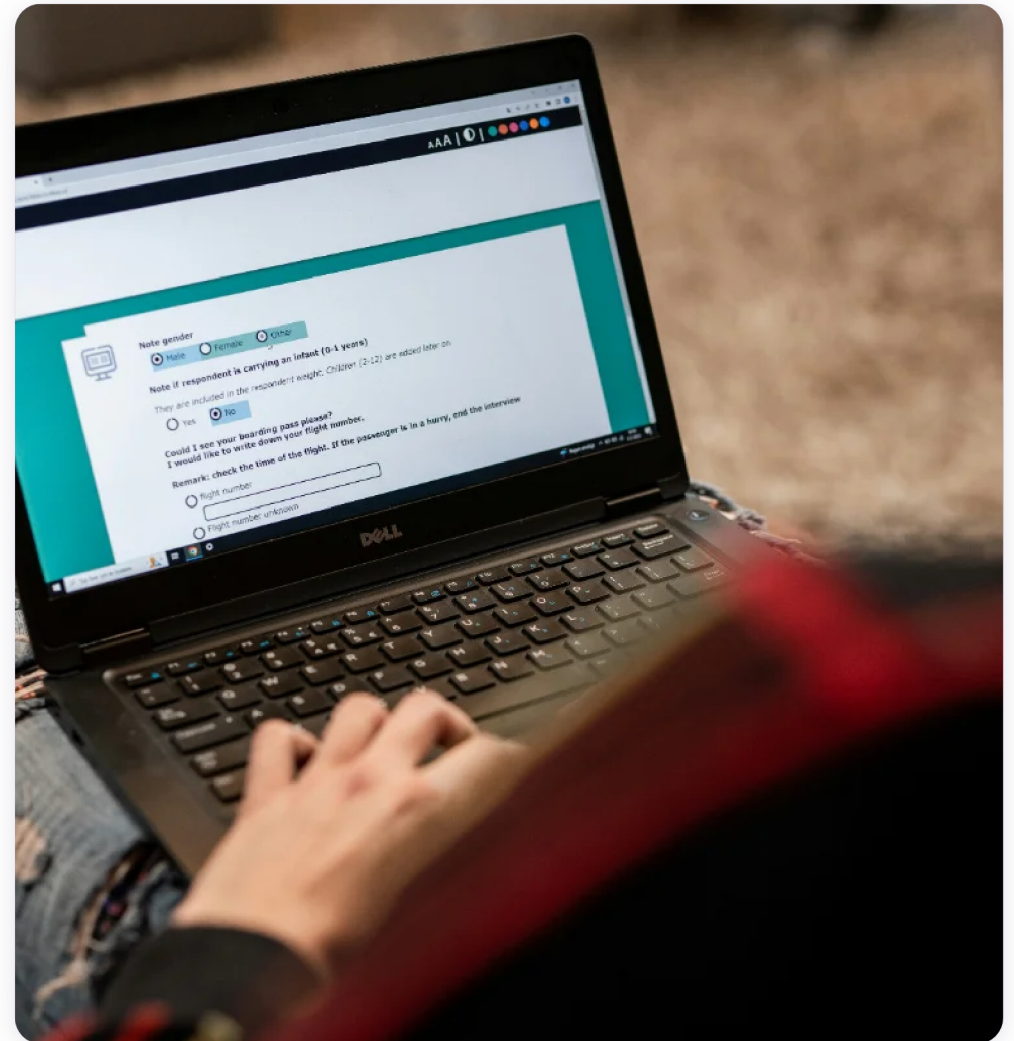
User survey

A quantitative snapshot at scale. Supplement interviews with it — never let it replace them.

DISCOVERY

QUANTITATIVE

5-10 MIN



— STAGE 1 · DISCOVERY

User interviews

Open questions and careful probing. The richest qualitative source in the whole process.

DISCOVERY

QUALITATIVE

45–60 MIN



— STAGE 1 · DISCOVERY

Shadowing

Observe users without interfering. Surfaces the workarounds they never think to mention.

DISCOVERY

OBSERVATION

IN CONTEXT



— STAGE 1 • DISCOVERY

Stakeholder interviews

Business context, goals, and constraints — never a substitute for talking to real users.

DISCOVERY

ALIGNMENT

30–45 MIN



— STAGE 1 · DISCOVERY

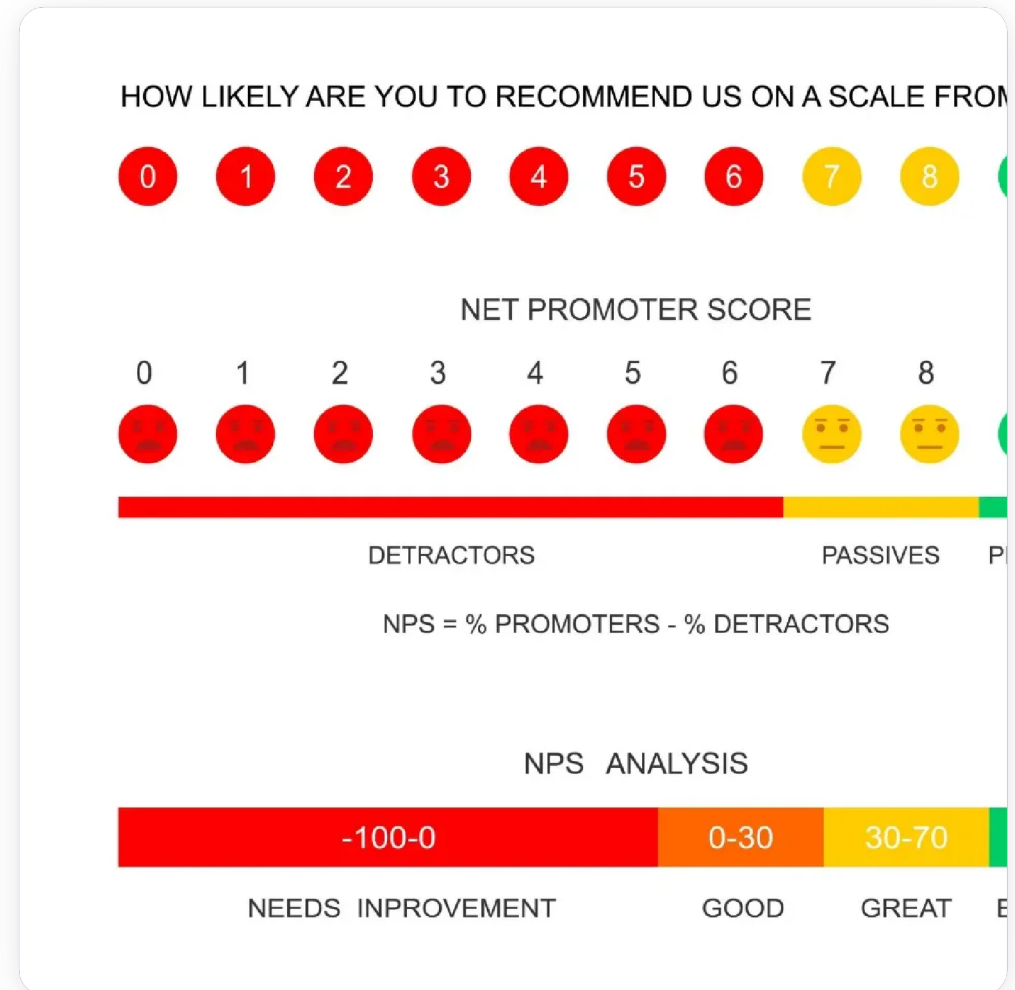
Support & NPS analysis

Mine existing tickets and verbatims for patterns before you talk to anyone new.

DISCOVERY

EXISTING DATA

ONGOING



— SOURCE SUPPORT DASHBOARD

— STAGE 1 • SYNTHESIS

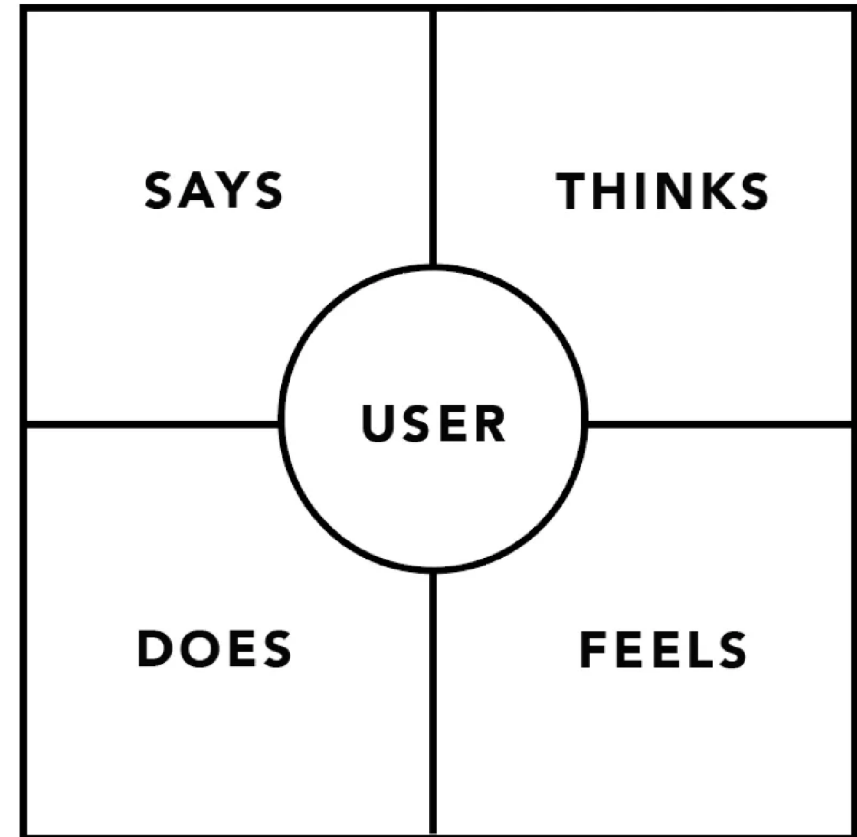
Empathy mapping

Say / Think / Do / Feel — capture what users actually said and did, kept separate from what you inferred.

SYNTHESIS

WORKSHOP TEMPLATE

30-45 MIN



NNGROUP.COM **NN**/g

— SOURCE NN/G TEMPLATE

— STAGE 1 • SYNTHESIS

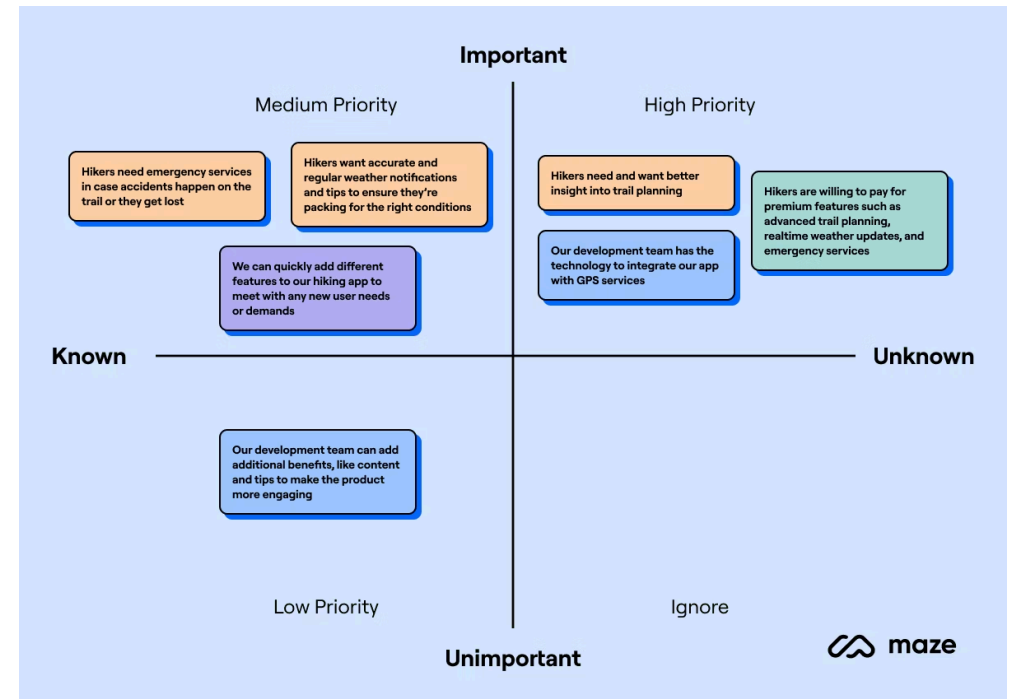
Assumption map

Move every belief from Unknown to Confirmed or Unconfirmed. Surfaces the untested assumptions.

SYNTHESIS

RISK MAPPING

30 MIN



— SOURCE MAZE

Research log update

An entry after every conversation: quote, behaviour, context. Builds a real evidence base.

SYNTHESIS

DOCUMENTATION

ONGOING

RAGWANA AKRAM 12C

RESEARCH LOG

DATE	Source of information	Description of information	NOTES
22 nd September 2014	http://www.regenthighschool.org.uk/Learning/Extra-Curricular-Beyond-the-Classroom/	Lists of activities available in Regents high school: http://www.regenthighschool.org.uk/docs/Clubs_and_activities/Extra_curricular_clubs_and_activities_Half_Term_1_2014.pdf	These are useful for the radio interview because it tells me number of students choose to attend these as these activities are run by pupils asking for them. It also shows the school's commitment of having 32 extra-curricular clubs open.
22 nd September 2014	http://www.egaschool.co.uk/content/130/clubs--activities	Lists of activities available EGA: http://www.egaschool.co.uk/vendor/s/userfiles/files/Sept%202014%20Autumn%20term%20schedule.pdf	This is useful information for me because it tells me that there are 27 extra – curricular clubs after school. It shows how there are pupils who would like to be attending these clubs.
22 nd September 2014	http://www.haverstock.camden.sch.uk/page_viewer.asp?page=Extended+Schools&pid=133	Lists of activities available in Haverstock school: http://www.haverstock.camden.sch.uk/_includes/attachments/P142/ZZ-Extended%20curricprogrammeautumn2014.pdf	The information that I have is useful because it tells me the sorts of clubs are available for students at Haverstock school. It also shows that to attend some of these activities students must be committed to come to them.

02 STAGE TWO

Define

What is the real problem worth solving?

— STAGE 2 • DEFINE

Lean UX canvas

Problem, user, solution hypothesis, metrics, and assumptions captured in a single view.

DEFINE

CANVAS

60 MIN

Lean UX Canvas (v2)

Title of solution

Date

Iteration

Business Problem

What problem does the business have that you are trying to solve?
(Goal: Describe your current challenge and how they drive value, changes in the market, delivery of services, competition threats and customer behavior.)

1

Users

What type of users and customers should you focus on first?
(Goal: Who buys your product or service? What user story can't they solve on their own?)

3

Hypotheses

Combine the assumptions from 2, 3, 4 & 5 into the following hypothesis statement:
"We believe that (business outcome) will be achieved if (user) does (behavior) with (feature)."
(Goal: Each hypothesis should focus on one behavior only.)

6

Solutions

What can we make that will solve our business problem and meet the needs of our customers at the same time? (Cut product, feature, or enhancement ideas here.)

5

Business Outcomes

How will you know you solved the business problem? What will you measure?
(1st: What will people/users be doing differently if your solution works? Or better metrics that indicate customer success like average order value, time on site, and retention rate.)

2

User Outcomes & Benefits

Why would your users seek out your product or service? What benefit would they gain from using it? What behavior change can we observe that tells us they're satisfied? (1st: great! 2nd: better money, good a promotion, spend more time with family.)

4

What's the most important thing we need to learn first?

For each hypothesis from box 5, identify 1 critical assumption. Then determine the fastest way to learn. This is the assumption that will cause the entire idea to fail if it's wrong.
(Hint: In the early stages of a hypothesis focus on ways to make either true feasibility.)

7

What's the least amount of work we need to do to learn the next most important thing?

Design experiments to learn as fast as you can whether your initial assumptions are true or false.

8

— SOURCE LEAN UX CANVAS

Jobs-to-be-done

DEFINE FRAMEWORK 45 MIN



— STAGE 2 · DEFINE

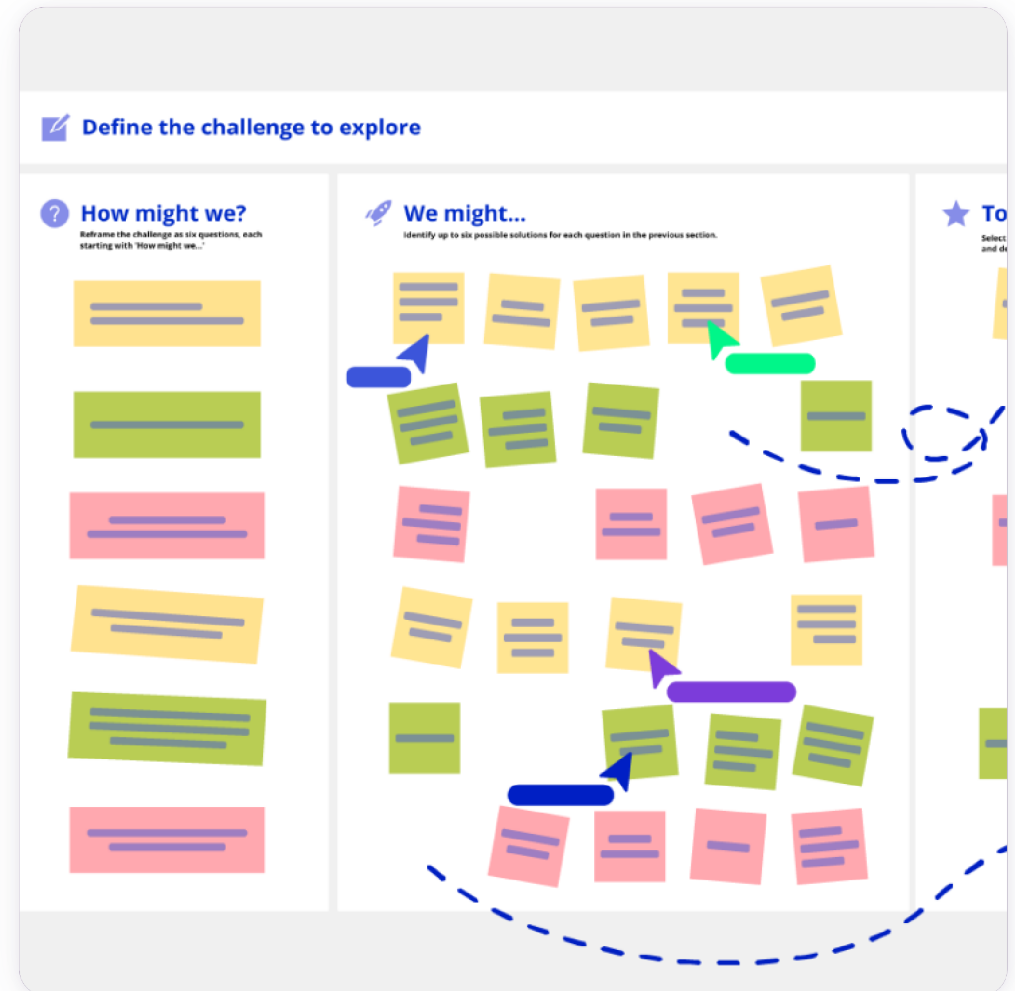
How might we

Convert each insight into a design opportunity — not too broad, not too narrow.

DEFINE

REFRAMING

20 MIN



— SOURCE HMW WALL

— STAGE 2 • DEFINE

Current-state journey

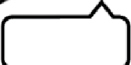
Map the experience exactly as it is today — not as it should be.

DEFINE

JOURNEY MAP

60 MIN

CUSTOMER/USER JOURNEY MAP

SPECIFIC USER + SCENARIO + GOALS		
PHASE 1	PHASE 2	PHASE 3
1. _____ 2. _____ 	3. _____ 4. _____ 5. _____ 6. _____ 	7. _____ 8. _____ 9. _____ 
OPPORTUNITIES + INTERNAL OWNERSHIP		

NNGROUP.COM **NN**

— SOURCE JOURNEY MAP

03 STAGE THREE

Ideate

What are all the possible ways to solve it?

— STAGE 3 · GENERATE

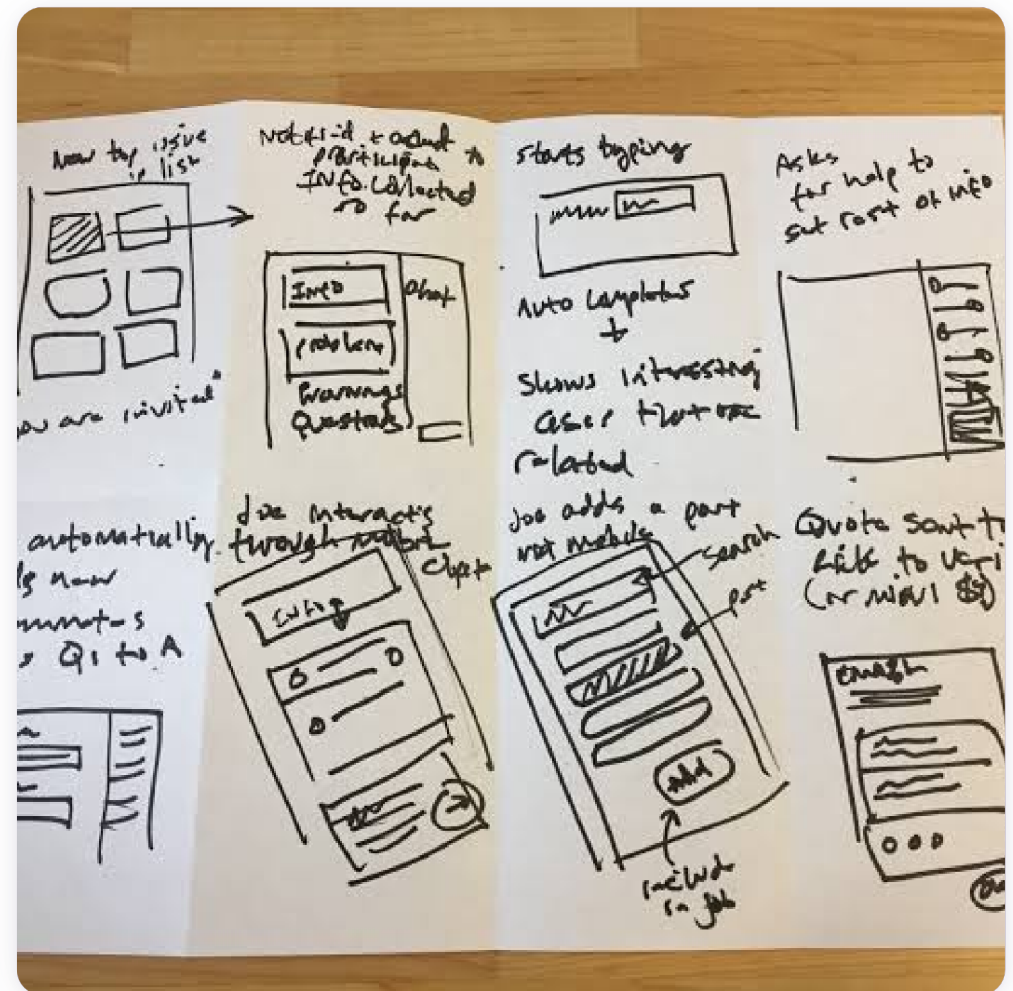
Crazy 8s

Eight sketches in eight minutes. Forces volume and kills perfectionism.

GENERATE

SKETCHING

8 MIN



— SOURCE CRAZY 8S SHEET

— STAGE 3 · GENERATE

HMW ideation

Five to ten ideas per question. The question itself is the useful constraint.

GENERATE

IDEATION

15 MIN



— SOURCE IDEA WALL

— STAGE 3 · GENERATE

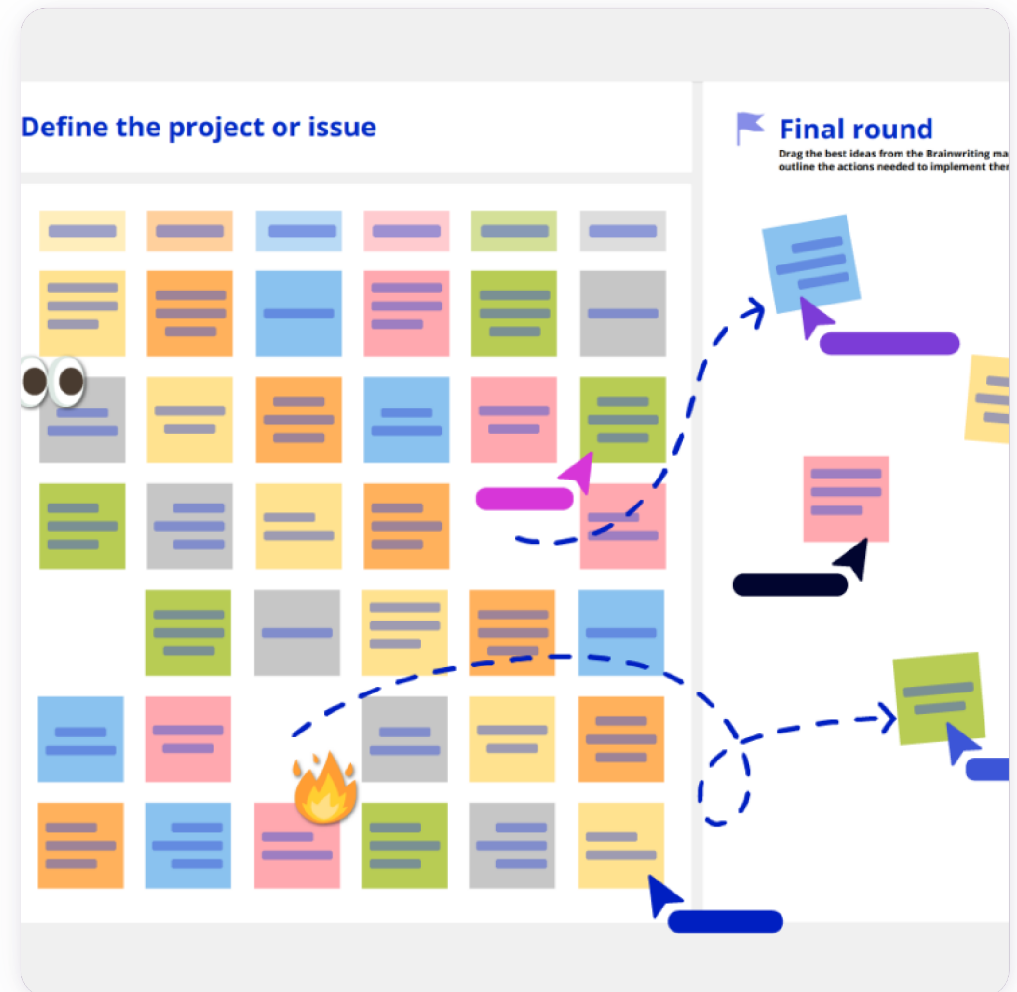
Brainwriting

Silent, parallel idea generation. Prevents the loudest voice from steering the room.

GENERATE

GROUP METHOD

20 MIN



— SOURCE BRAINWRITING GRID

— STAGE 3 • GENERATE

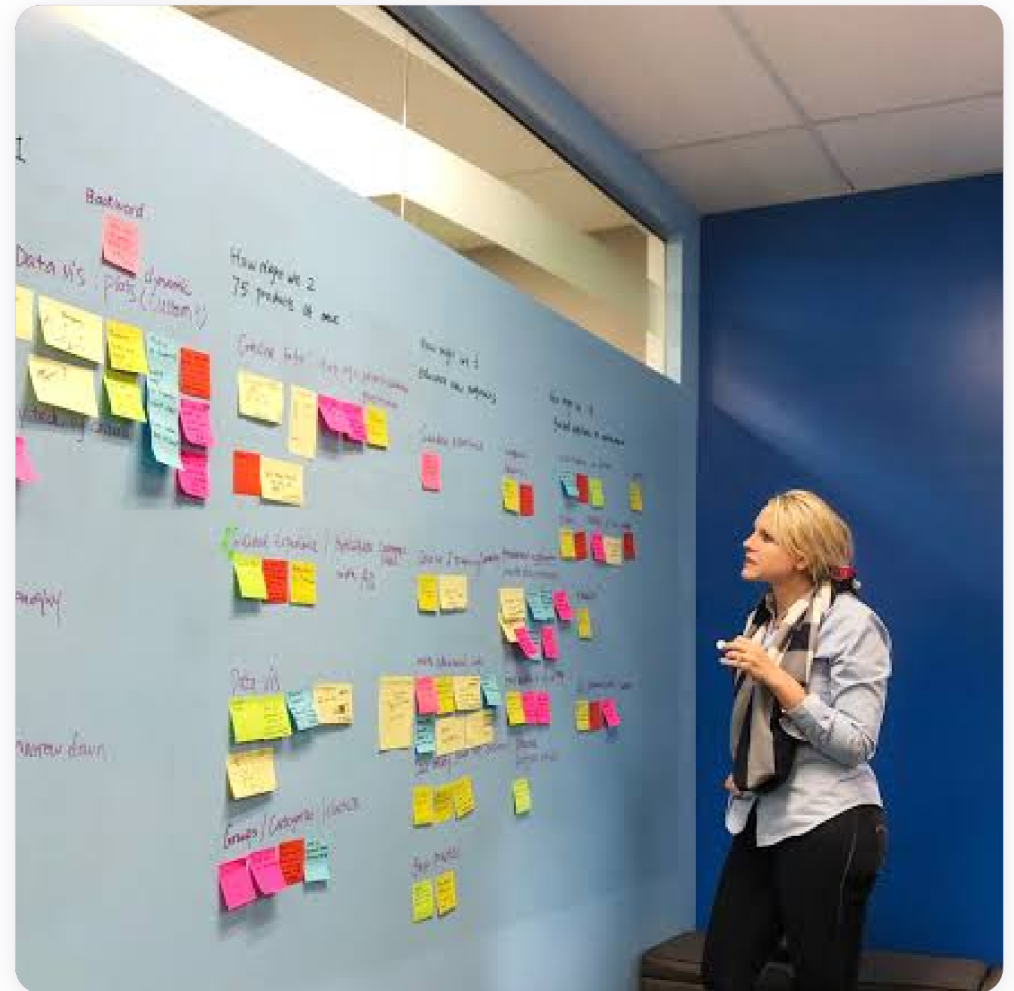
Ideate workshop

Crazy 8s and HMW back-to-back — fifty-plus ideas to dot-vote from.

GENERATE

WORKSHOP

90 MIN



— SOURCE WORKSHOP BOARD

— STAGE 3 · SELECT

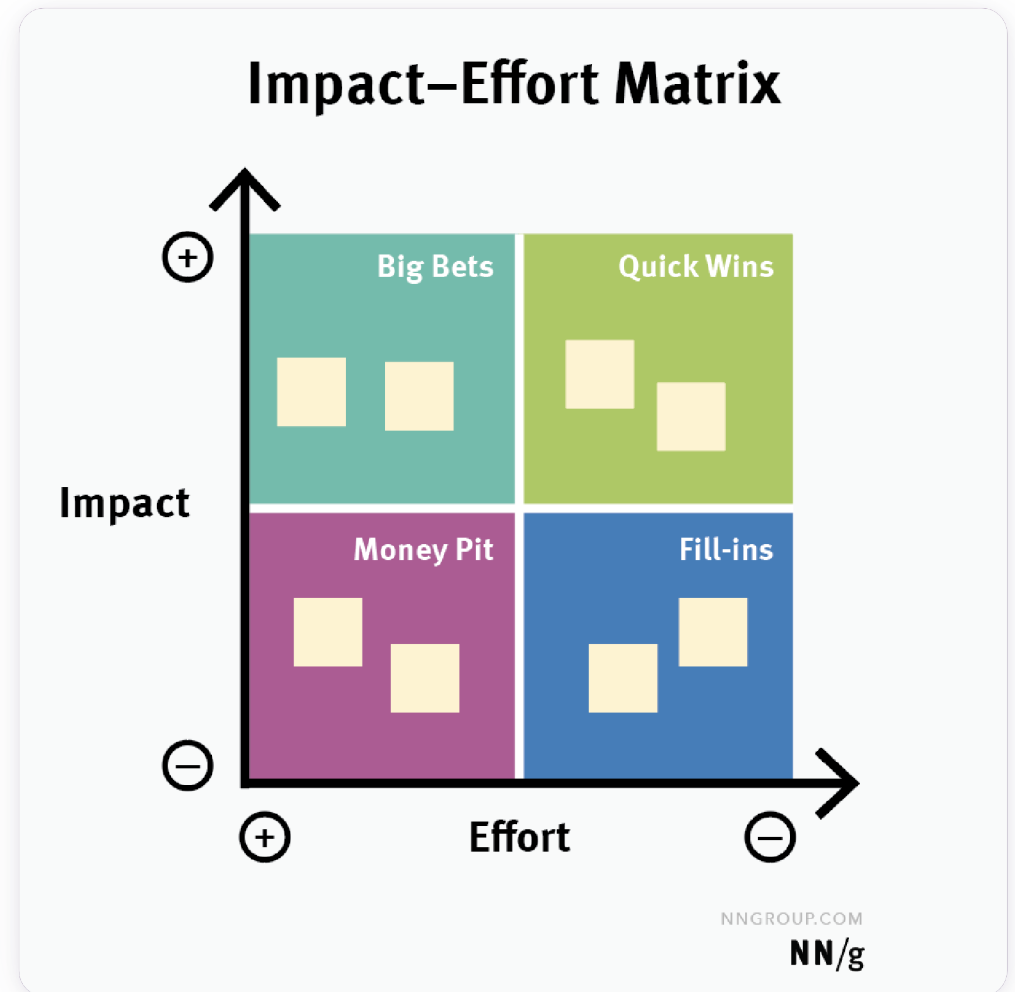
Impact vs effort

Plot ideas by user value against build cost. Start with the top-left quadrant.

SELECT

PRIORITISATION

30 MIN



— SOURCE 2×2 MATRIX

— STAGE 3 • SELECT

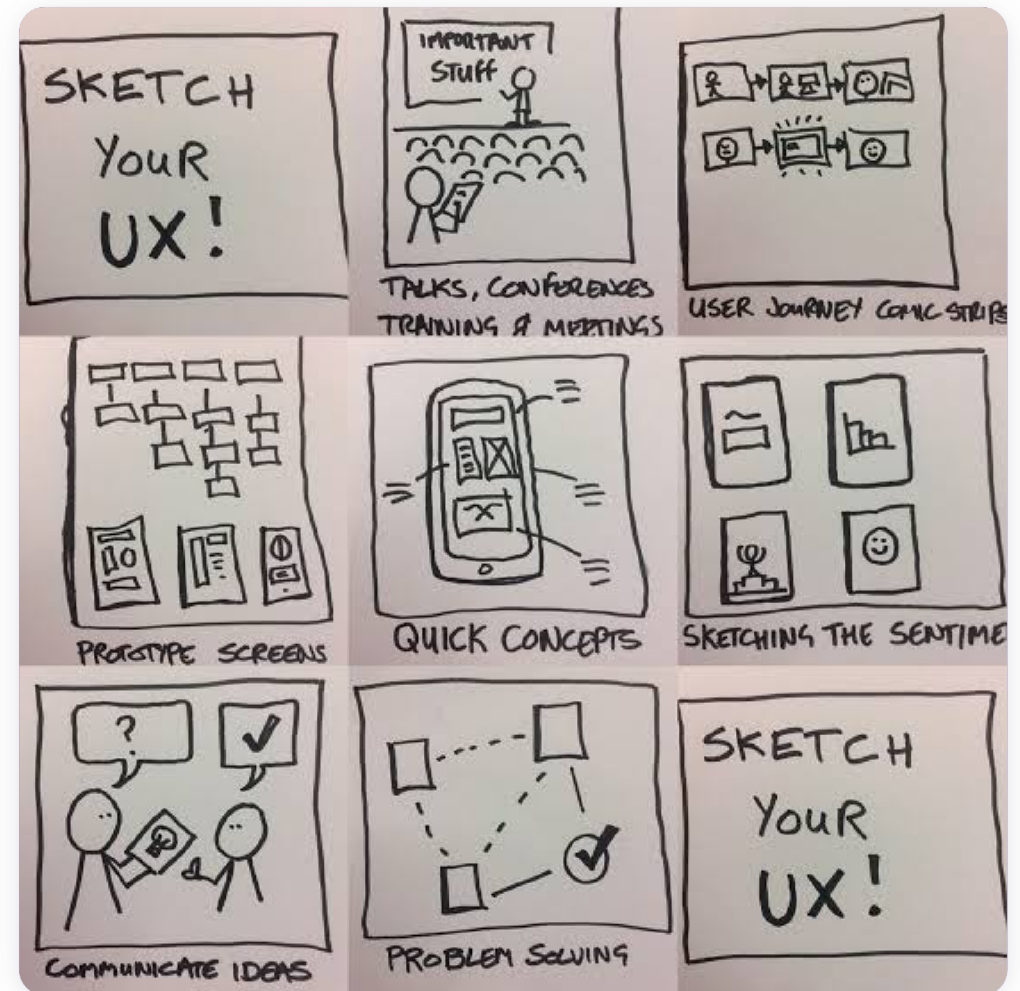
Concept sketching

Develop the top two or three directions into fuller sketches with a narrative.

SELECT

CONCEPTING

45 MIN



— SOURCE CONCEPT SKETCHES

— STAGE 3 · SELECT

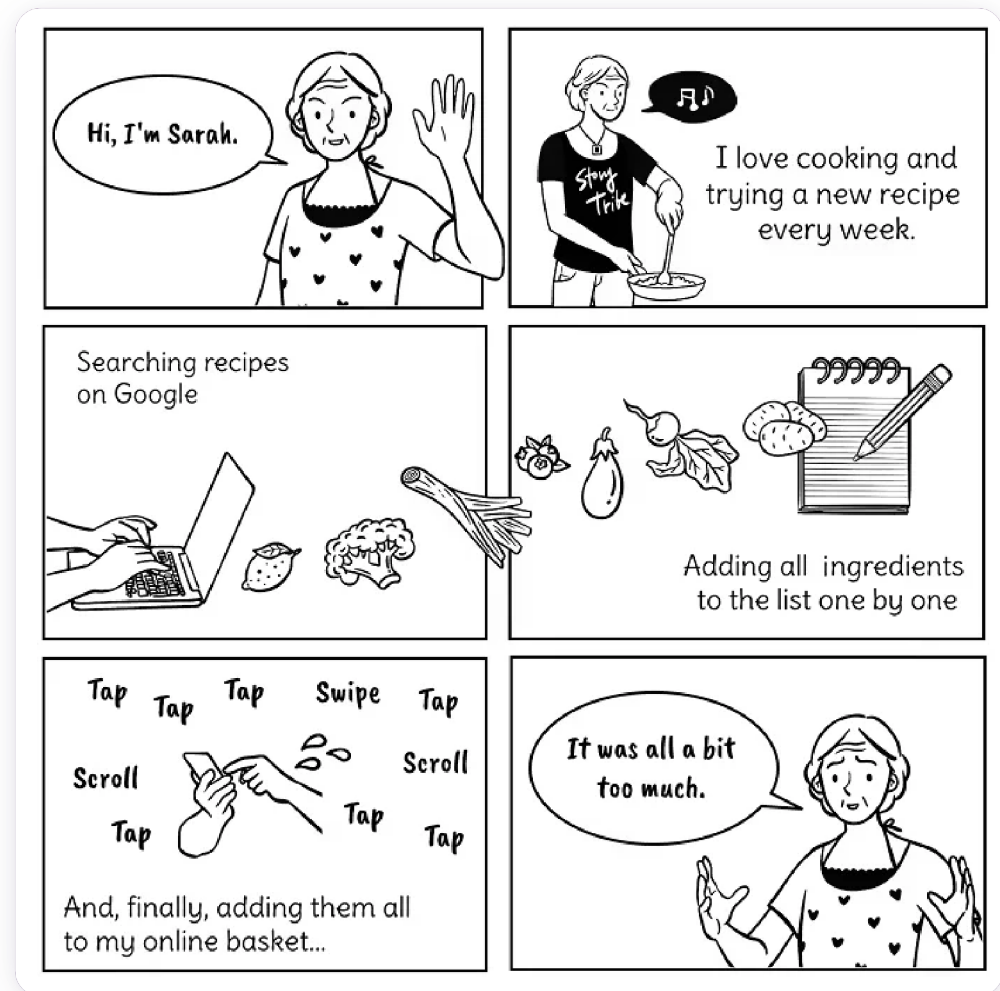
Storyboarding

Show how the concept plays out for a user in their real context.

SELECT

NARRATIVE

45 MIN



— SOURCE EXAMPLE UX STORYBOARD CREATED BY STORYTRIBE

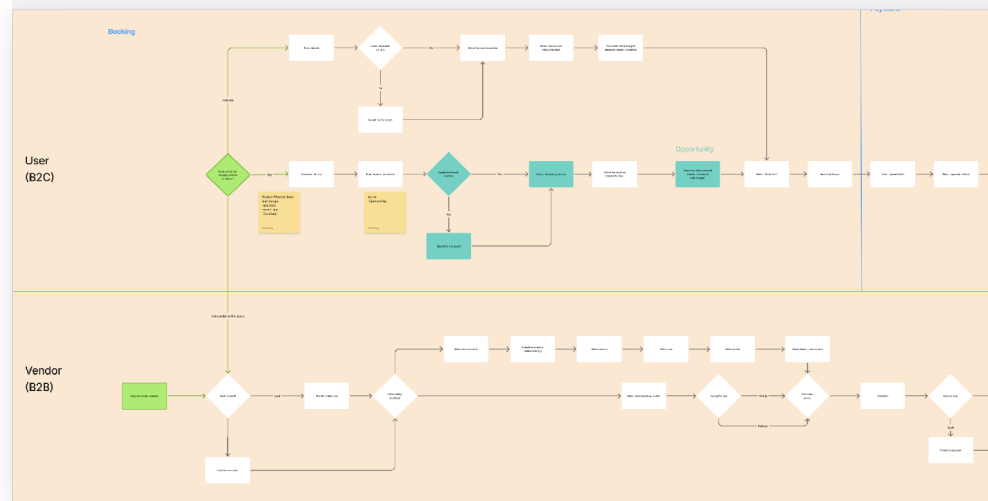
— STAGE 3 · SELECT

Proposed process map

Map the experience as it should feel once the solution is built.

SELECT

FUTURE STATE



— SOURCE ANH TRUONG

04 STAGE FOUR

Prototype

What is the fastest way to make this testable?

— STAGE 4 · BUILD FAST

Wireframes

Structural layout only. No colour, no brand, no distraction.

PROTOTYPE

LOW-FIDELITY

FAST



— SOURCE WIREFRAME SET

— STAGE 4 • BUILD FAST

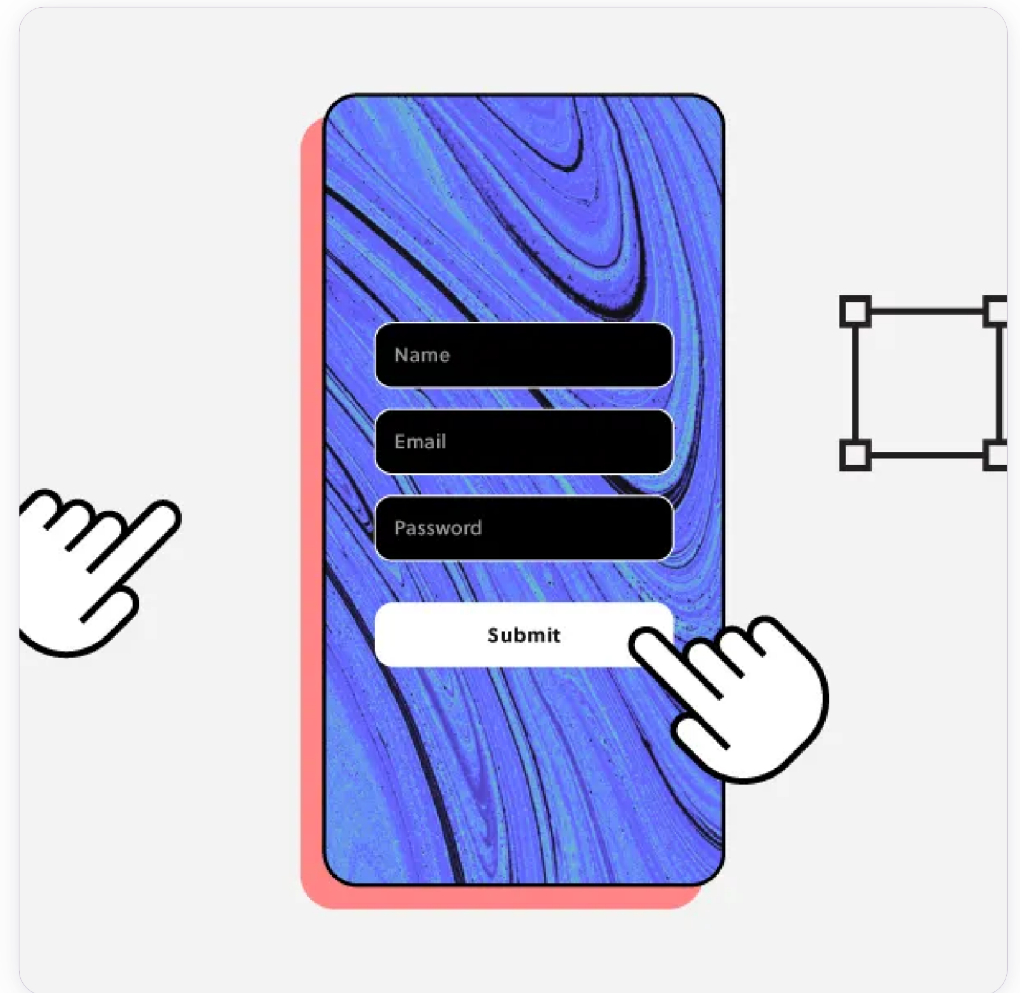
Interactive prototype

States and navigation — default, loading, empty, error, success.

PROTOTYPE

CLICKABLE

MID-FIDELITY



— SOURCE FIGMA PROTOTYPE

— STAGE 4 · BUILD FAST

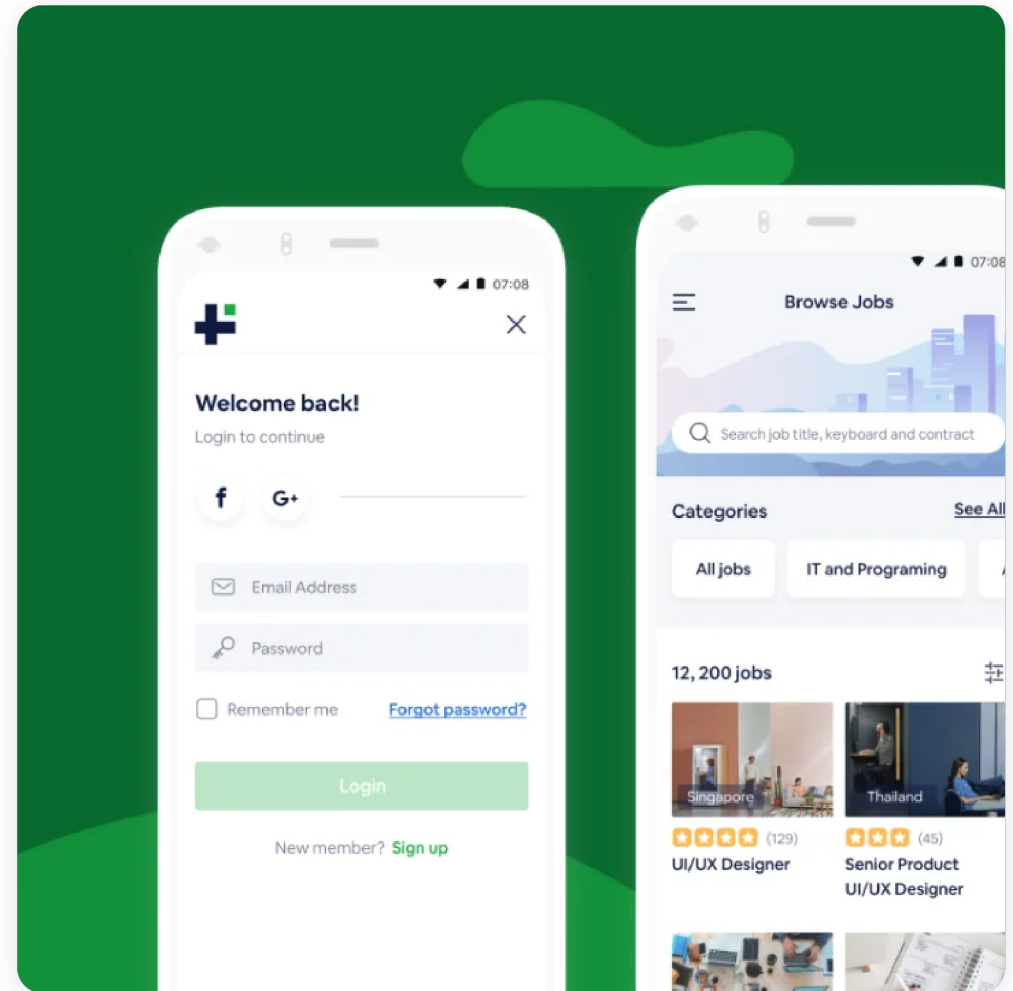
Proof of concept

Answers one question: does this idea actually work?
Keep it rough and fast.

PROTOTYPE

EXPERIMENT

THROWAWAY



— SOURCE POC BUILD

05 STAGE FIVE

Test

Were we right? What do we need to change?

— STAGE 5 • FIND OUT

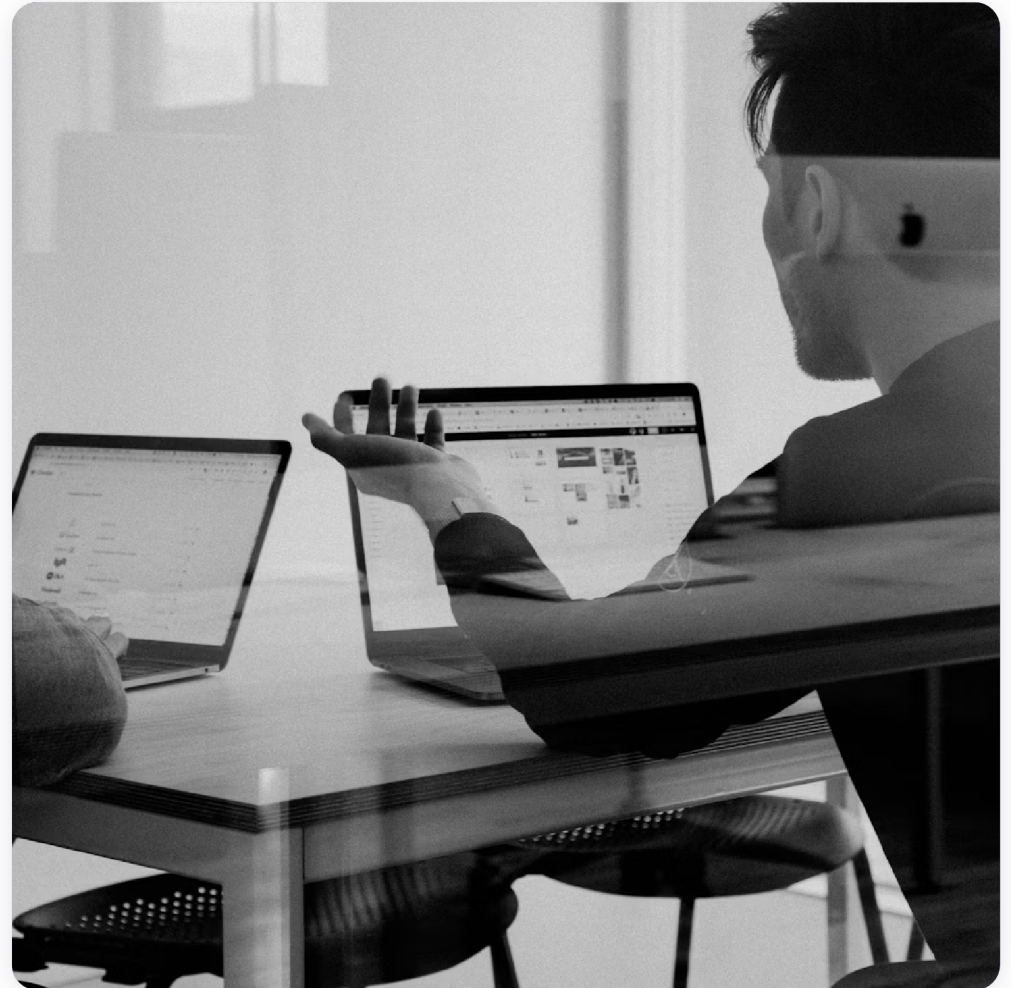
Internal feedback

I noticed / I wonder / What if — documents decisions
before anything ships.

TEST

CRITIQUE

30 MIN



— SOURCE CRITIQUE NOTES

— STAGE 5 • FIND OUT

Concept testing

Show a concept to a few users and measure comprehension before building.

TEST

QUALITATIVE

20 MIN

5SECOND USER TEST

To get insights on first-impressions, thoughts on a design



— SOURCE TEST SESSION

— STAGE 5 · FIND OUT

Usability testing

Think-aloud protocol. Five users reveal about 85% of the critical issues.

TEST

MODERATED

30–45 MIN



— SOURCE USABILITY SESSION

— STAGE 5 · FIND OUT

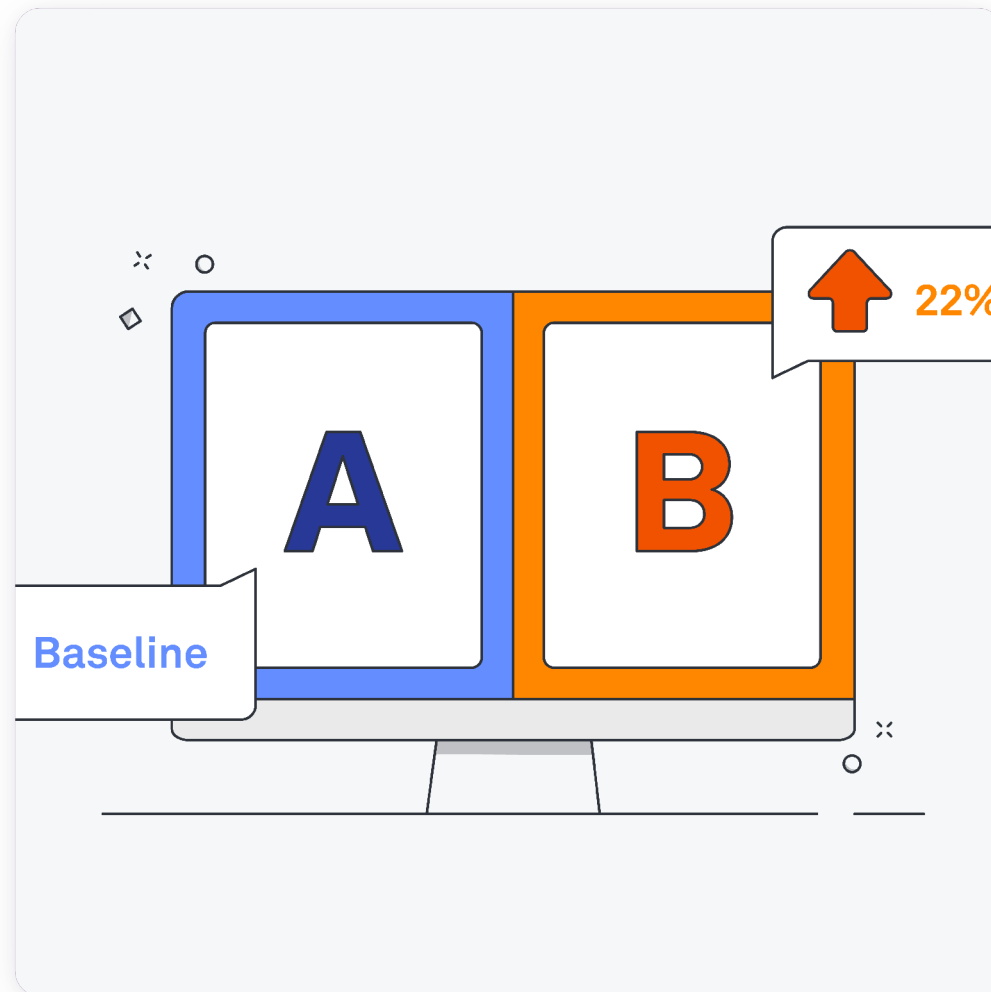
A/B testing

Compares two live versions. Answers which is better — not why.

TEST

QUANTITATIVE

LIVE



— SOURCE EXPERIMENT RESULTS

ACTIVITY · YOUR TURN

10 minutes — draft it

Open the shared board and use your real project. For each stage, write one activity and one output. Come back with one stage you're confident about — and one where you're stuck.

Draft your process — one stage at a time

EMPATHISE	DEFINE	IDEATE	PROTOTYPE	TEST
ACTIVITY _____	ACTIVITY _____	ACTIVITY _____	ACTIVITY _____	ACTIVITY _____
OUTPUT _____	OUTPUT _____	OUTPUT _____	OUTPUT _____	OUTPUT _____

PROMPT "I'm a UX designer working on [project]. My users are [who they are]. For each Design Thinking stage, suggest one key activity, one output to produce, one sign I'm ready to move on, and the biggest risk if I skip the stage."

— BEFORE NEXT SESSION

Set up + document

ASSIGNMENT 01 • SET UP YOUR PROCESS

Build the board

- Choose a real project to work with.
- Add at least one activity and one output per stage.
- Set it up in your project-management tool.
- Share and agree on a workspace with your team.

ASSIGNMENT 02 • COMPLETE THE BRIEF

Draft the brief

- Draft your problem statement — three versions with the AI prompt.
- Describe your primary user in 2–3 sentences.
- List three design goals and any known constraints.
- Update it after your stakeholder interview.

— BEFORE NEXT SESSION

Capture + interview

ASSIGNMENT 03 · CAPTURE CURRENT SCREENS

Map the flow

- Identify key experiences — onboarding, core task, checkout, settings.
- Screenshot each screen and label each state.
- Arrange them in a screen-flow layout.
- We'll use these for friction analysis in Session 2.

ASSIGNMENT 04 · STAKEHOLDER INTERVIEW

Have the conversation

- Prepare a 5–8 question script.
- Focus on experience, pain points, constraints, success criteria.
- Record your notes immediately after.
- Update your design brief from what you learned.

ONE THING TO CARRY FORWARD

Not a checklist. A habit.

Start with empathy. Define the real problem. Generate before you judge. Build to learn. Test before you ship.

— *Winnie Nguyen*